

OpenPrivateer Player Manual

Public Alpha

OpenPrivateer is a modern reimplementation of *Wing Commander: Privateer*. It runs the game natively on modern systems while using the original game data.

OpenPrivateer does not include the original Origin/EA game assets. You need your own copy of *Privateer* and, if you want to play it, *Righteous Fire*.

This is a player manual. The reverse-engineering notes and file-format documentation in the source tree go much deeper.

1. Quick Start

1. Download and extract OpenPrivateer.
2. Copy `PRIV.TRE` and `INITCFG.PAK` into the OpenPrivateer folder.
3. Start `openprivateer.exe` on Windows, or the corresponding executable on Linux or macOS.
4. Choose **NEW**.
5. Play.

For *Righteous Fire*, also copy `RF.TRE` and `INITRF.PAK`.

If both games are present, OpenPrivateer shows a Privateer / Righteous Fire selector at startup.

The INIT files matter. They contain the original new-pilot starting state. If the required INIT file is missing, **NEW** is disabled.

GOG installation

In the GOG release, the original files may be inside `GAME.GOG`. Despite the extension, this is a disc image. Open it with 7-Zip, extract the required files and place them next to the OpenPrivateer executable.

A basic installation looks roughly like this:

```
OpenPrivateer/

  openprivateer.exe

  PRIV.TRE

  INITCFG.PAK

  RF.TRE

  INITRF.PAK

  openprivateer.ini

  savegame/

  music/

  wallpaper/

  content/

  alpha/
```

You do not need *Righteous Fire* to play the original campaign.

2. First Start

OpenPrivateer creates its optional folders and README files automatically. The README files are rewritten on startup so their instructions stay in sync with the installed engine.

Folder	Purpose
savegame/	Original and OpenPrivateer savegames
music/	Optional replacement music
wallpaper/	Optional game-selection artwork
content/	Content overrides and translations
alpha/	Optional material from the August 1993 Privateer alpha

You can ignore all of these folders when starting out.

Settings are stored in `openprivateer.ini` next to the executable.

3. Privateer and Righteous Fire

OpenPrivateer supports both the original *Privateer* campaign and *Righteous Fire*.

When both `PRIV.TRE` and `RF.TRE` are present, the startup selector lets you choose which game to run. The selection is remembered. You can also change the game later from the settings/debug overlay. Changing games relaunches OpenPrivateer because the two modes use different data archives.

Importing a Privateer pilot into Righteous Fire

The original Righteous Fire import flow is supported.

If Righteous Fire is selected and `savegame/` contains Privateer `.SAV` files, starting **NEW** can ask whether you want to load an old Privateer ship.

The import carries over the pilot, ship, credits, reputation, kills, guild memberships and missions-to-date state according to the original import behavior. Privateer cargo, side missions and plot progress do not become Righteous Fire campaign state.

4. Experience Modes

OpenPrivateer has three experience settings:

- **Classic**
- **Enhanced**
- **Modern**

Enhanced and Modern currently use the same gameplay behavior. The separate Modern setting exists for future changes.

Classic

Classic aims to reproduce the original gameplay, mechanics and feel. It is not a DOS emulator, and it does not deliberately reproduce every hardware limitation or arithmetic accident of the old engine.

Confirmed original behavior is kept where it was part of normal play, including many UI rules, equipment rules, cutscene rules and gameplay quirks.

OpenPrivateer additions such as multiple-ship ownership are not active in Classic.

Enhanced and Modern

Enhanced and Modern keep the original game underneath but allow OpenPrivateer conveniences and additions, including optional multiple ships and hired wingmen.

They also contain some deliberate quality-of-life changes, such as corrected sprite aspect while rolling and extra convenience controls.

If you want to compare OpenPrivateer directly with DOS Privateer, use **Classic**.

If you want OpenPrivateer's extra features, use **Enhanced** or **Modern**.

The Experience setting can be changed while playing. A connected multiplayer session is different: its Experience mode is fixed by the server.

5. Settings and Debug Overlay

During the Alpha, some settings still live in the debug/settings overlay rather than a finished front end.

Press:

~

This is normally the key to the left of **1** on an English keyboard. Its label depends on your keyboard layout.

The overlay contains settings for areas such as Experience mode, Privateer / Righteous Fire mode, audio, SoundFont, rendering, subtitles, Mission Computer style, controllers, multiple ships, hired wingmen and update checking.

Some settings are disabled in Classic because they would change original gameplay.

6. Controls

OpenPrivateer supports keyboard, mouse, gamepads, joysticks and HOTAS-style controllers.

Open **Controls...** from the settings interface to inspect or remap controls. Controller bindings are stored per device.

The same Controls screen can also be reached by pressing **K** on the Options screen, opened in flight or on a base with **Alt+O**.

OpenPrivateer can bind controller buttons, hats, axis directions and full analog axes.

Calibration

OpenPrivateer supports joystick calibration. A raw joystick needs at least two axes and one button to qualify as a flight controller. SDL-recognized gamepads are accepted directly.

If several devices are attached, devices that cannot actually fly the ship are skipped.

Default gamepad layout

Input	Default action
Left stick Y	Pitch
Left stick X	Yaw
Right stick X	Roll
Right stick Y	Throttle
Right trigger	Fire guns
Right shoulder	Fire ordnance
Left trigger	Afterburner

Input	Default action
Left shoulder	Cycle target
South button	Target lock
East button	Cycle ordnance
West button	Cycle guns
North button	Toggle ITTS
Start	Pause
Back	Navigation Map

These are normal remappable bindings.

Joystick pointer

A calibrated joystick can move the pointer on base and menu screens, matching a feature of the original game. The joystick trigger acts as the click. SDL gamepads use the A/South button.

7. New Game, Load and Save

The title screen has **NEW**, **LOAD**, **OPTIONS** and **QUIT**.

NEW

NEW starts from the original data in `INITCFG.PAK` or `INITRF.PAK`. If the matching file is missing, NEW is greyed out.

LOAD

Privateer saves use `.SAV`. Righteous Fire saves use `.PRS`.

Put existing DOS saves in:

```
savegame/
```

OpenPrivateer reads the original save format.

SAVE

Use the Mission Computer and choose **SAVE**.

Saving under a typed name never overwrites a file. Matching the original game, the name always gets `_NEW` appended (then `_NEW2`, `_NEW3`, ...) rather than reusing the plain name. Typing `PILOT` creates `PILOT_NEW.SAV`, not `PILOT.SAV`; saving under that same name again creates `PILOT_NEW2.SAV`, and so on.

Some OpenPrivateer-only state cannot fit inside the original DOS save format. That state is stored in a matching `.openpriv.json` sidecar while the `.SAV` or `.PRS` remains in the original format.

If you use parked ships or other OpenPrivateer-only persistent features, keep the sidecar together with its save.

8. Mission Computer

The Quine 4000 handles saves and pilot information.

Its important pages are:

- **MISSIONS**: active plot mission and accepted side missions
- **FIN**: cash, kills and faction standing
- **MAN**: cargo manifest
- **SAVE / LOAD**: save browser

A pilot can carry up to three side missions. The active plot mission is separate and does not consume one of those slots.

Classic uses the original Mission Computer presentation. Enhanced and Modern can use the alternate OpenPrivateer presentation through the **Quine Model** setting.

9. Bases

Base navigation is driven by the original OPTIONS and GAMEFLOW data.

Move the pointer over doors, people and terminals to see available actions, then click normally.

Depending on the base you may find the Launch Pad, Main Concourse, Bar, Commodity Exchange, Ship Dealer, Repair & Upgrade, Mission Computer, Merchants' Guild or Mercenaries' Guild.

Not every base contains every service.

10. Commodity Exchange

The Commodity Exchange buys and sells cargo.

Prices and availability depend on the base economy. Cargo consumes hold space. Mission cargo follows the game's normal cargo rules.

The secret compartment, once obtained through the story, has separate hidden capacity.

11. Ship Dealer and Repair & Upgrade

With normal single-ship play, buying another hull follows the original trade-in model. The current hull and sellable equipment contribute to the trade-in value.

Repair & Upgrade handles ship equipment.

In Classic, entering Repair & Upgrade always starts in **Buy** mode on the first item, matching the original. Enhanced and Modern remember the previous mode and item where possible.

A damaged scanner can be repaired in the Software Booth's Repair Mode. Repair cost is based on the damaged scanner entry and damage percentage, matching the original game.

12. Multiple Ships and Fleet Selector

Multiple ships are an OpenPrivateer feature.

To use them:

1. Switch to Enhanced or Modern.
2. Enable **Allow Multiple Ships**.
3. Buy another hull.

Instead of trading in the old ship, OpenPrivateer parks it at the current base and makes the new hull active.

On a Launch Pad press:

```
S
```

to open the Fleet Selector.

The active ship is marked as current. Parked ships can be selected or sold. Remote selection of a ship parked at another base is supported.

Multiple ships are not active in Classic.

13. Hired Wingmen

Hired wingmen are an OpenPrivateer feature built on top of multiple-ship ownership.

Enable **Allow Multiple Ships** and **Allow Hired Wingmen** in Enhanced or Modern mode.

A hired pilot flies one of your actual owned parked ships. If the wingman survives, the ship returns with its live equipment state. If it is destroyed, the ship is lost.

Pilots have persistent callsigns and skill. Confirmed kills can improve their skill. Launching with a wingman costs a sortie fee.

A ship assigned to a hired pilot cannot simply be selected or sold as an ordinary parked ship.

Custom callsigns

The callsign pool is stored in:

```
content/wingmen/callsigns.json
```

OpenPrivateer creates the default file if it is missing and does not overwrite an edited version.

The file is a JSON array of non-empty strings. Existing pilots keep their callsigns. Changes affect later hires.

Plain ASCII names are safest with the original game fonts.

14. Flight

The flight model is reconstructed from the original game rather than replaced with a new one.

Implemented systems include flight control, throttle, afterburner, guns, ordnance, targeting, ITTS, radar, scanners, navigation, autopilot, jumps, docking, tractor beam, turrets, equipment damage and Repair Droid behavior.

Scanner

Targeting requires a working scanner.

With no scanner fitted, the radar is absent and scanner-dependent targeting functions are unavailable. There is no hidden free scanner.

Autopilot

Autopilot follows the original instant-travel behavior. It can drop out early when the route enters another encounter zone, including asteroid or navigation encounter areas.

Pause

Press **P** in flight.

15. Navigation Map

The Navigation Map uses the original sector and quadrant data.

It shows systems, nav points, bases, jump points and mission objectives. Story-locked systems and routes remain hidden until the game makes them available.

Active mission targets are highlighted.

The optional **Open Universe** setting exposes additional universe content and is not part of Classic behavior.

16. Guilds and Random Missions

The Merchants' Guild, Mercenaries' Guild and Mission Computer provide the original non-plot mission types:

- Cargo
- Patrol
- Scout
- Defend
- Attack
- Bounty

Guild fees are:

Guild	Fee
Merchants' Guild	1,000 credits
Mercenaries' Guild	5,000 credits

Both guild computers show the original **Scanning ... records ... Please stand by...** stage while generating a fresh batch of offers.

17. Music and Sound

OpenPrivateer supports several music backends, including OPL2, MIDI with an external SoundFont, OS MIDI and CD-style replacement music. Availability depends on the platform.

SoundFont

Select a `.sf2` file from the SoundFont setting when using the corresponding MIDI backend. The path is stored in `openprivateer.ini`.

Replacement music

The `music/` folder accepts optional replacement music. WAV, MP3 and FLAC are supported.

Use the generated `music/README.txt` for the current slot and filename rules. That README is kept in sync with the installed build.

18. Graphics

OpenPrivateer renders the original game at its native logical resolution and scales it for modern displays.

Available settings include CRT filtering, image adjustments, scaling, texture filtering, pixel scaling and splash font selection.

Classic deliberately keeps some confirmed original rendering behavior. Enhanced and Modern apply some presentation improvements, such as keeping round sprites round while the ship rolls.

19. Wallpaper

The `wallpaper/` folder accepts custom artwork for the Privateer / Righteous Fire selector.

Use filenames beginning with:

```
01_
```

for Privateer and:

```
02_
```

for Righteous Fire.

PNG, JPG and BMP are supported. See `wallpaper/README.txt` for the current details.

20. Content Overrides and Translations

OpenPrivateer can load replacement files from the filesystem without changing the original TRE archives.

The basic layout is:

```
content/  
  priv/  
  rf/  
  i18n/
```

`content/priv/` and `content/rf/` mirror paths inside the corresponding original archive.

Translations live under `content/i18n/` with names such as:

```
openprivateer_de.i18n
```

The translation format uses `key=value`, `#` comments and `\n` for embedded line breaks.

The original fonts have limited character coverage. Plain ASCII or transliteration is safest unless a suitable custom font is used.

21. Optional 1993 Alpha Content

The `alpha/` folder is for optional material from the August 1993 Privateer alpha.

It is not distributed with OpenPrivateer and is not required to play.

See `alpha/README.txt` for the exact files expected by your build.

22. Multiplayer

OpenPrivateer includes dedicated client/server multiplayer. It is still an Alpha feature.

Server

Basic example:

```
openprivateer_server --tre /path/to/PRIV.TRE
```

The default UDP port is `24601`.

Useful server options include `--port`, `--max-players`, `--verbose` and `--experience-mode`.

Client

Basic example:

```
openprivateer --connect HOST:24601 /path/to/PRIV.TRE
```

The server can reject clients when important session properties differ, including build, Privateer vs. Righteous Fire data or Experience mode.

Multiplayer covers the shared flight/combat environment. The normal single-player campaign progression is not the multiplayer campaign model.

23. Update Check

Release builds can check for a newer OpenPrivateer build at most once every 24 hours.

Nothing is downloaded or installed automatically.

When a newer build exists, the title screen shows:

```
New build available
```

```
Click to download
```

Left-click opens the download page. Right-click dismisses that particular build notice.

The check can be disabled in settings or for one launch with:

```
--no-update-check
```

24. Original Developer Switches

OpenPrivateer supports several switches from the original game:

```
-K
```

Skip the intro.

```
-B<n>
```

Start at original base ID `n`.

```
-D<n>
```

Set starting credits to `n`.

Example:

```
openprivateer.exe -K -B39 -D100000
```

These are mainly useful for testing and development.

25. Debug Tools

The Alpha contains debugging tools used during reconstruction and testing.

Open the settings/debug overlay with:

```
~
```

Toggle the base click-region overlay with:

```
R
```

The region overlay draws clickable areas in green and is useful for screenshots when reporting a base UI problem.

26. Troubleshooting

NEW is greyed out

The matching seed file is missing. Privateer needs `INITCFG.PAK` ; Righteous Fire needs `INITRF.PAK` . Put it next to the executable.

The game data cannot be found

Check that `PRIV.TRE` is next to the executable. For Righteous Fire, check `RF.TRE` too.

With the GOG release, the files may first need to be extracted from `GAME.GOG`.

An old save does not appear

Privateer saves must be `.SAV`, Righteous Fire saves `.PRS`. Put them in `savegame/`.

The controller is detected but does not fly the ship

Open **Controls...**, check the device and calibration, then verify the axis bindings. A raw joystick needs at least two axes and one button.

MIDI is silent

Check the selected music backend. If using SoundFont MIDI, make sure a valid `.sf2` file is selected.

Something behaves differently from DOS Privateer

Check the Experience mode first. Use **Classic** for direct comparisons with the original.

If the difference remains in Classic, report it.

Windows Defender reports the executable

New unsigned software can occasionally trigger heuristic antivirus detections. Do not blindly whitelist a file.

Make sure the binary came from the official OpenPrivateer release, then update Windows Security's security intelligence and scan it again. During Alpha testing, an unchanged OpenPrivateer release binary stopped being detected after a Defender signature update.

If a current official build is still detected, report the build ID and exact detection name.

27. Reporting Bugs

A useful Alpha bug report includes:

- OpenPrivateer build ID
- Privateer or Righteous Fire
- Classic, Enhanced or Modern
- what you expected
- what happened
- exact reproduction steps
- whether it happens every time
- the savegame when relevant
- a screenshot or video for visual problems

Print the build ID with:

```
openprivateer --version
```

For base-screen problems, a screenshot with the **R** region overlay can help.

You do not need to decide whether something is an OpenPrivateer bug or an original Privateer quirk before reporting it. Describe what happened and it can be checked against the original.

28. What Alpha Means

OpenPrivateer is playable, but it is still an Alpha.

The normal single-player Privateer path is implemented, and Righteous Fire support is under active reconstruction and testing. Obscure cases are still being found as more people play the game.

Expect bugs, unfinished polish and occasional behavior changes as the original game becomes better understood.

Save before doing anything adventurous.

29. Help and Downloads

Project website:

<https://openprivateer.org/>

Downloads:

<https://openprivateer.org/#downloads>

Discord:

<https://discord.gg/5H3vW2STqW>

When asking for help, include the build ID and whether you are playing Privateer or Righteous Fire.

30. Legal Note

OpenPrivateer is a reimplementation of the game engine.

It does not ship the copyrighted game data from *Wing Commander: Privateer* or *Righteous Fire*. You must provide the original game files yourself.

Wing Commander, *Privateer*, *Righteous Fire* and related names and assets belong to their respective rights holders.

31. One-Minute Checklist

For Privateer:

- ☐ Extract OpenPrivateer
- ☐ Copy PRIV.TRE
- ☐ Copy INITCFG.PAK
- ☐ Start OpenPrivateer
- ☐ Leave Experience on Classic for original behavior
- ☐ Click NEW

For Righteous Fire:

- ☐ Copy RF.TRE
- ☐ Copy INITRF.PAK
- ☐ Select Righteous Fire

For an old pilot:

- ☐ Copy .SAV or .PRS into savegame/
- ☐ Click LOAD

For OpenPrivateer's extra features:

- ☐ Switch to Enhanced or Modern
- ☐ Open the settings overlay with ~
- ☐ Enable the features you want

Have fun.